which is based on the idea of refugeehood, and for turning it into a major obstacle, perhaps even the main obstacle, to the resolution of the conflict.

Today it is widely agreed that the conflict's core issues are (1) Jerusalem, (2) territory, (3) borders, (4) security arrangements, and (5) refugees. But I believe that the refugee problem, combined with the "right of return," is far more influential than the others. I also believe that as time passes, the weight of the refugee problem continues to grow and become an obstacle to peace that may even overshadow the challenge represented by all of the other core issues put together.

The first time that the problem of refugees was dealt with in an international framework was after the First World War. The destruction caused by the war, and even more the massive border changes, created a serious refugee problem. The League of Nations, which was established at the end of the war, appointed a special commissioner for refugee affairs. This was Fridtjof Nansen, the Norwegian ambassador to the League of Nations, the first researcher to reach the North Pole, a renowned zoologist and oceanographer, and a world recordbreaking ice skater with a reputation for being impeccably honest and decent. In his capacity as the League of Nations' high commissioner for refugees, he devised the "Nansen passport," a document of identity for people in foreign countries, and helped them emigrate to countries that were willing to absorb them. More than fifty countries—the vast majority of the world's countries at that time — recognized the Nansen passport, and it helped tens of thousands of people in their efforts to resettle in other countries. Among the famous personalities who emigrated using the Nansen passport were the painter Marc Chagall, the composer Igor Stravinsky, and the ballet dancer Anna Pavlova. Nansen also managed to raise substantial funds to help the victims of the famine that hit Russia in 1919 to 1922, following the civil war. Perhaps his greatest achievement was the role he played negotiating the population exchange agreement between Turkey and Greece, in which more than a million Greeks left areas under Turkish control, and half a million Turks left Greek-controlled territories, all in an organized and orderly manner that also included some financial compensation. For this and his other accomplishments, Nansen was awarded the Nobel Peace Prize in 1922.

The refugee problem at the end of the World War I was dwarfed by the problem that was created in 1945, at the conclusion of World War II. Tens